difference between India and other nations', wrote Yijing, 'is the peculiar distinction between purity and impurity'. They described ongoing tussles between Brahmins and Bodhisattvas. These Chinese monks' records, translated in the nineteenth century, helped rediscover India's Buddhist antiquity (after Buddhism declined and vanished from India, its texts, monuments and even the Buddha himself were forgotten by the Indians).

One such rediscovery was Nalanda Mahavihara, a Buddhist monastery in Bihar often considered the first university in the world. Between the fifth and thirteenth centuries, monks from across Asia came here to learn grammar, logic, philosophy, theology, astronomy and medicine. I wander its tranquil ruins and attempt to conjure up the lives of its monks in the seventh century. I introduce their famous teachers and their notable theories, examine the university's financing and more. In the late first millennium, both Indian Buddhism and Nalanda declined for reasons surprisingly different from those peddled in popular histories. I reflect on the stark contrast between Bihar's illustrious past and its dismal present.

In 1001 CE, Mahmud of Ghazni began his infamous plundering raids in the subcontinent. In this period, Alberuni—a brilliant scholar, scientist and polyglot—spent thirteen years studying Indian society and culture. I consider his account of India, which he had written to provide, in his own words, 'the essential facts for any Muslim who wanted to converse with Hindus and to discuss with them questions of religion, science, or literature'. Few pre-modern travellers can match his insights into Indian life and thought. His account shows that on the eve of the Turko-Persian invasions, Brahminical society wasn't exactly a picture of intellectual and moral well-being that many now fondly imagine it to be.

I board a train to see the temples of Khajuraho, famed for their erotic art. Built between 950 and 1100 CE, they were later swallowed up by a forest and eventually discovered as archaeological ruins by a British engineer only in 1838. I seek answers to what every modern visitor likely wonders: What does this erotic art mean? How did a culture that exalts penance and renunciation depict sex so vividly on temple walls, next to their gods? What social milieu permitted such depictions that scandalize Indians today? And why did this tradition disappear entirely from temple art across India? For a site as famous as Khajuraho, it's astonishing that most popular histories and local guides get the answers almost entirely wrong.